

PickBook

Product Requirements Document

Version 3.0 · May 2026 · Legal Sources · In-App Reading · Personalisation

Product Name	PickBook
Document Version	3.0 — Legal content pipeline + fully in-app reading experience
Date	May 2026
Platform	Web (Desktop + Mobile-responsive PWA)
Key Change v3	All novel content sourced legally; zero user redirects to external sites

§1 Executive Summary

PickBook is a free, browser-based novel reading platform. This v3.0 PRD resolves two critical issues from v2: **(1) the content sourcing strategy is now fully legal** — every novel is either public domain, Creative Commons licensed, or contributed by the author with explicit permission; and **(2) users never leave PickBook to read** — all content is imported, stored, and served directly from PickBook's own database. The personalisation engine from v2 is retained in full.

§2 Legal Content Framework

This is the most important section of the PRD. Every novel on PickBook must fall into one of three legal categories before it is published. No exceptions.

Category	Type	Definition	Legal Status
Category 1	Public Domain	Copyright has expired. Free to copy, host, distribute, and display without permission.	■ Fully legal. Safe to automate.
Category 2	Creative Commons (CC)	Author published under a CC license (CC BY, CC BY-SA, CC BY-NC, etc.). Specific license terms must be respected (attribution, non-commercial, etc.).	■ Legal if attribution shown and license terms met.
Category 3	Author Submission	Author explicitly grants PickBook a non-exclusive right to host and display their work via the submission portal. They retain copyright ownership.	■ Legal via signed digital consent at upload time.

■ What Is Explicitly FORBIDDEN

Scraping any website that prohibits it in its Terms of Service — even if the content looks freely available. (Webnovel, Wattpad, NovelUpdates, LightNovelWorld, etc. all prohibit scraping.)

Hosting any novel that is under active copyright without a signed license or the author's explicit written consent.

Mirroring content from Royal Road, Scribble Hub, or similar platforms without contacting each individual author and receiving opt-in approval.

Using a robot/crawler to bulk-download from any source not listed as approved below.

§3 Approved Content Sources

The following sources are pre-approved for automated ingestion. All are either public domain, CC-licensed, or provide a legal API/feed specifically for this purpose.

Source	URL	License	Ingestion Method	Volume	Genre Coverage
Project Gutenberg	gutenberg.org/ebooks	Public Domain (pre-1928)	Official REST API + bulk mirror at gutenberg.org/robot/harvest	70,000+	Classics, Drama, Mystery, Romance, History, Sci-Fi
Standard Ebooks	standardebooks.org	Public Domain	OPDS feed at standardebooks.org/opds — explicitly permits redistribution	800+	Cleaned, beautifully formatted classics across all genres
Feedbooks Public Domain	feedbooks.com/publicdomain	Public Domain	OPDS Catalog API — free access, no scraping needed	5,000+	Fiction, Romance, Horror, Sci-Fi, Thriller
Open Library (PD only)	openlibrary.org	Public Domain only — filter by license	Official REST API at openlibrary.org/developers/api	Millions (filter)	All genres — must verify PD status per book via API flag
LibriVox Texts	librivox.org	Public Domain	Books are sourced from Gutenberg; use Gutenberg API instead	Covered by Gutenberg	Redundant — use as fallback verification only
Manybooks.net	manybooks.net	Public Domain / CC	OPDS feed available — TOS permits redistribution for non-commercial use	50,000+	Wide genre coverage including Romance
CC-licensed authors	Various	Creative Commons	Manual discovery + author contact. Attribution shown on every page.	Growing	Fills Romantic, Erotic, Business gap not covered by PD
Author Submissions	pickbook.com/submit	Owner-granted license	PickBook upload portal — author checks consent box (logged with timestamp + IP)	Unlimited	All genres — primary source for modern content

3.1 Attribution Requirements for CC Content

Every novel sourced under a Creative Commons license MUST display on its detail page: Author name, original source URL, and the exact CC license name (e.g. CC BY-NC 4.0).

If the license prohibits commercial use (CC BY-NC), PickBook must not run ads on that novel's pages — ever.

Attribution is stored in the database alongside the novel record and rendered automatically by the frontend. It is NOT optional.

§4 Content Ingestion Pipeline

The pipeline fetches from approved sources, stores all content in PickBook's own database, and serves it directly to users. **No user is ever redirected to an external site to read.**

Step 1 — Scheduled Fetch (daily cron): Worker queries each approved API/OPDS feed, downloads EPUB or plain-text files to a private S3-compatible object store. No browser, no scraping — only official API endpoints.

Step 2 — License Verification: Each record's license field is checked. If the API returns anything other than 'Public Domain' or a CC identifier, the record is quarantined for manual review. It is NOT auto-published.

Step 3 — Parse & Extract: ebooklib (Python) parses EPUB into: title, author, cover image, synopsis, chapter list, and full UTF-8 chapter text.

Step 4 — Store in PickBook DB: All text is written to PostgreSQL. Cover images go to Cloudflare CDN. The original EPUB file is retained in object storage for audit purposes. **The source site is no longer needed after this step.**

Step 5 — AI Enrichment: A lightweight classifier adds genre tags, mood tags (dark romance, slow burn, action-packed, etc.), and estimated reading time per chapter.

Step 6 — Attribution Record: Source URL, license type, and author credit are stored and linked to the novel. Rendered automatically on the detail page.

Step 7 — Publish: Novel appears live on PickBook. Users read from PickBook's own database — zero dependency on the source site being online.

Step 8 — Deduplication: SHA-256 hash of (title + author) prevents duplicates from multiple sources.

§5 In-App Reading — Zero External Redirects

This is a core product principle. A user who arrives on PickBook never needs to visit another website to read a novel. Everything — discovery, browsing, reading, bookmarking — happens inside PickBook.

■ OLD BEHAVIOUR (removed)	■ NEW BEHAVIOUR (v3.0)
Novel detail page has a 'Read on Gutenberg' external link	Full chapter text is stored in PickBook DB and rendered natively
Clicking 'Read' opens a new tab on the source website	Clicking 'Read' opens PickBook's own reader view — same tab
Reading experience depends on source site being online	PickBook serves content from its own CDN — always available

Each source has a different reading UI — inconsistent	Every novel uses PickBook's unified reader: dark theme, font controls, progress bar
User loses personalisation context when leaving the app	Every chapter read is tracked for recommendations — user stays in the loop
No 'Continue Reading' possible if user is on external site	Chapter progress saved to localStorage + server; resume from any device

5.1 Reader View Wireframe (fully in-app)

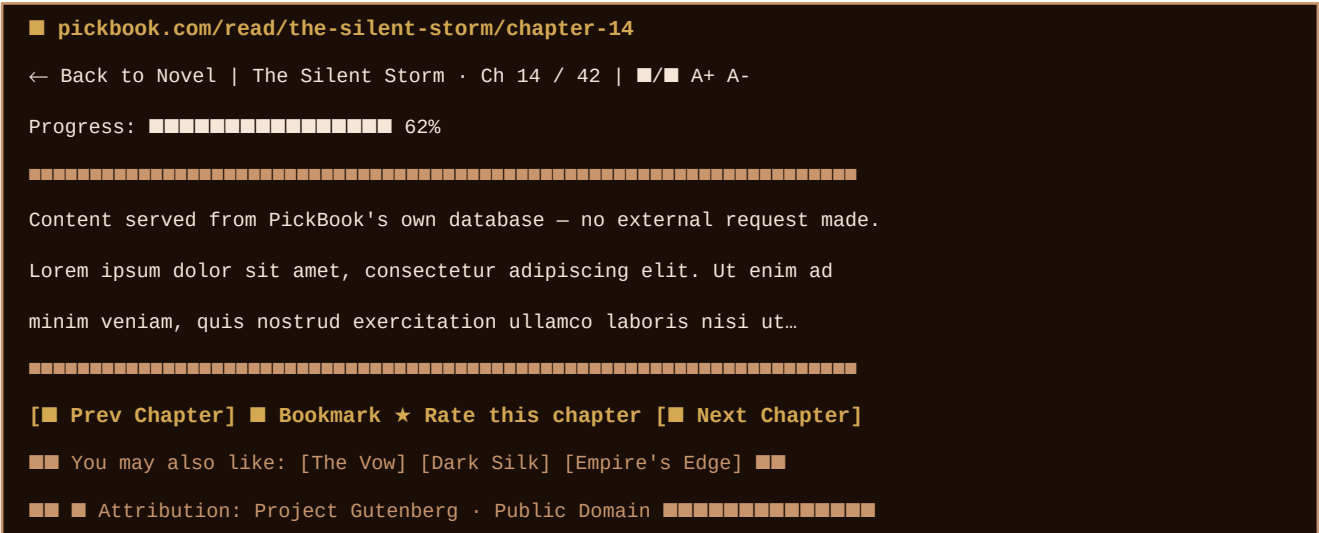


Figure 1 – Reader fully served from PickBook. Attribution shown at bottom.

§6 Homepage Interface

6.1 Homepage Wireframe (Dark Mode — Default)

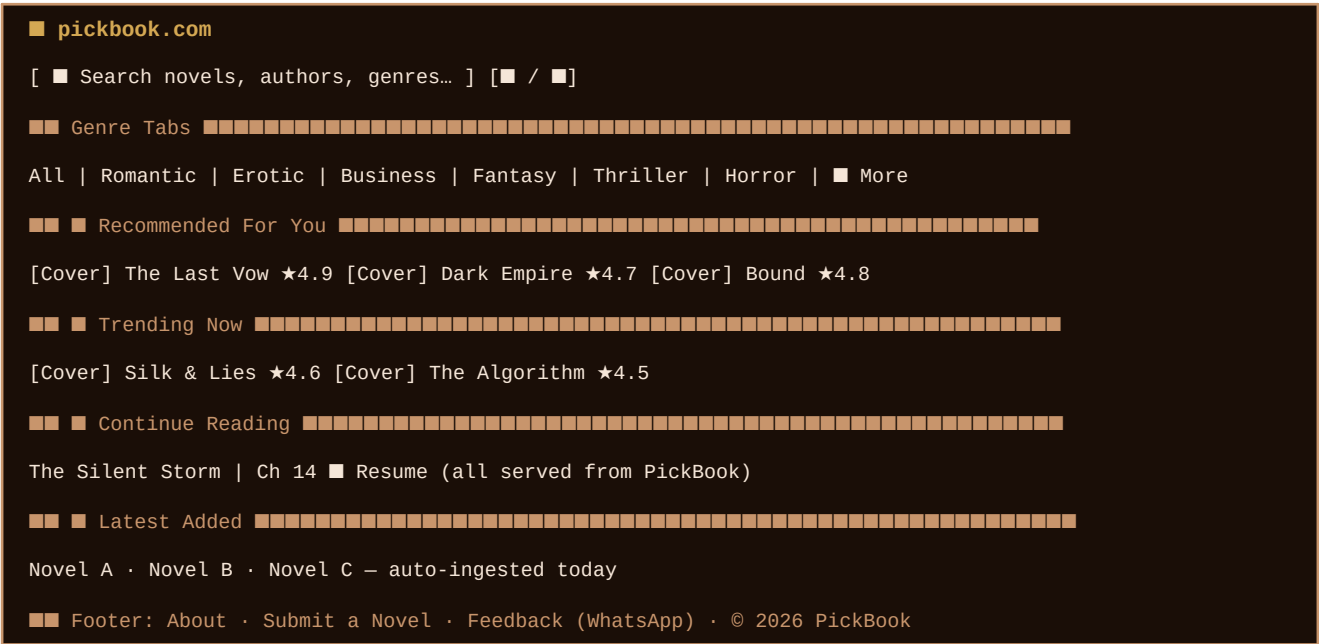


Figure 2 – Homepage in default dark mode with personalised shelves

§7 Personalisation Engine

Because all reading happens inside PickBook, every user action — click, scroll, chapter completion, rating — is captured and used to personalise the experience. No data is lost to external sites.

7.1 Signal Collection

Genre tab clicks	Indicates genre interest. Weight: low.
Novel detail view	Shows intent to read. Weight: medium.
Chapter reads (≥30%)	Strong engagement signal. Weight: high.
Novel completion	Strongest positive signal. Weight: very high.
Star ratings	Explicit feedback. Weight: very high.
Reading time/chapter	Engagement quality indicator.
Bookmarks	Explicit save = strong interest. Weight: high.
Chapter drop-offs	Left after Ch 1 = soft negative signal. Weight: medium.

7.2 Engagement Mechanics

Mechanism	How It Works
■ Reading Streak	Daily streak counter on homepage. Resets if user skips a day. Proven driver of daily returns.
■ Continue Reading	Persistent strip — last novel + chapter. One-tap resume. localStorage + server sync.
■ Cliffhanger Nudge	Push notification 24h after mid-chapter drop: 'You left off at Ch 14 — continue?'
■ Update Badge	Red dot on bookmarked novels when a new chapter is added. Creates urgency to return.
■ Milestone Badges	Silent personal achievements: '5 novels read', 'Night Owl'. Toast notification only.
■ Taste Picker	First-visit: pick 3 genres → seeds cold-start recommendation profile immediately.
■ Mood Filter	Browse by mood: 'Dark Romance / Light-hearted / Edge-of-seat'. Maps to AI mood tags.
■ Weekly Digest	Optional opt-in email: new chapters in saved novels + 3 personalised picks.

§8 Genre Tabs

Tabs sit beneath the global search bar on all pages. Horizontally scrollable on mobile.

Romantic	Erotic	Business	Fantasy	Thriller	Sci-Fi
Horror	Comedy	History	Drama	Self-Help	Mystery

§9 Theme System

9.1 Dark Mode (Default)

Background: #1A0E07 (deep espresso)

Surface / Cards: #2E1810

Primary Text: #F5E6D8

Accent / CTAs: #D4A853 (aged gold)

Tab active: #C8956C (caramel)

9.2 Light Mode (Switchable)

Background: #FDF6EE (cream parchment)

Surface / Cards: #F0E0CC

Primary Text: #2C1206

Accent / CTAs: #6B3A2A (mahogany)

- Toggle (■/■) fixed top-right. Saved in localStorage. Dark is default.
- CSS custom properties — zero JS flicker on load.

§10 WhatsApp Feedback

Feedback link in footer and hamburger menu. Tap →
 wa.me/{OWNER_NUMBER}?text=PickBook%20Feedback%3A%20

WhatsApp opens pre-filled with 'PickBook Feedback:' prefix. User types and sends.

Optional draft field on the feedback page so users compose before being redirected.

No account, no CAPTCHA, no email form.

Owner action: Replace {OWNER_NUMBER} with your WhatsApp number e.g. 2348012345678.

§11 Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement	Priority	Notes
FR-01	Global sticky search bar	Must-Have	Live search, genre/mood filter
FR-02	Genre tab navigation	Must-Have	Scrollable on mobile
FR-03	Novel detail page	Must-Have	Cover, synopsis, chapters, attribution
FR-04	In-app reader — all content served from PickBook DB	Must-Have	Zero external redirects
FR-05	Dark/light theme toggle	Must-Have	Dark default, localStorage persist
FR-06	WhatsApp feedback	Must-Have	wa.me deep-link, pre-filled text
FR-07	Automated ingestion pipeline (legal sources only)	Must-Have	PD + CC + Submissions
FR-08	License verification gate	Must-Have	Quarantine non-PD/CC records
FR-09	Attribution display on every novel page	Must-Have	Required for CC compliance
FR-10	Age gate — Erotic genre	Must-Have	18+ checkbox interstitial
FR-11	AI genre/mood auto-tagger	Must-Have	Runs at ingest time
FR-12	Taste Picker onboarding	Must-Have	Pick 3 genres on first visit
FR-13	'Recommended For You' shelf	Must-Have	Personalised, updates each session
FR-14	'Continue Reading' resume strip	Must-Have	localStorage + server sync
FR-15	Reading streak counter	Must-Have	Daily streak, homepage display
FR-16	'You May Also Like' in reader	Must-Have	Shown at end of each chapter
FR-17	Bookmark / My Shelf	Should-Have	Save novels, track progress
FR-18	Chapter update badge	Should-Have	Red dot on bookmarked novels with new chapters
FR-19	Browser push notification (nudge)	Should-Have	24h after mid-chapter drop-off
FR-20	Milestone badges	Should-Have	Personal only, toast notification

FR-21	Author submission portal	Should-Have	TXT/DOCX upload, consent checkbox
FR-22	Weekly email digest	Nice-to-Have	Opt-in only

§12 Tech Stack

Frontend	Next.js 14 (React) — SSR. Tailwind CSS with brown design tokens.
Ingestion Worker	Python (Celery + FastAPI). ebooklib for EPUB. Runs daily cron.
License Checker	Python script validates API license field before any record is published.
AI Tagger	OpenAI text-embedding-3-small or HuggingFace zero-shot classifier.
Database	PostgreSQL — novels, chapters, license records, attribution. Redis cache.
Object Store	Cloudflare R2 or AWS S3 — stores original EPUBs for audit trail.
Search	Meilisearch — fast, typo-tolerant, personalised ranking weights.
CDN	Cloudflare — serves cover images and static assets globally.
Hosting	Vercel (frontend) + Railway (API, DB, worker).
Analytics	Plausible — privacy-first, no cookie banner needed.

§13 Milestones

Milestone	Target	Deliverable
M1	Week 1–2	UI/UX Figma — all pages, both themes
M2	Week 3–4	Frontend scaffold, theming, genre tabs, search, taste picker
M3	Week 5	Legal ingestion pipeline — Gutenberg, Feedbooks, Standard Ebooks
M4	Week 6	License verifier, attribution storage and display, Open Library integration
M5	Week 7	In-app reader — serve from PickBook DB, font controls, progress bar
M6	Week 8	Recommendation engine, shelves, 'You May Also Like'
M7	Week 9	Engagement mechanics — streak, badges, nudge notifications, update badge

M8	Week 10	WhatsApp feedback, author submission portal, age gate, mobile QA
M9	Week 11	Beta with 1 000 seeded novels — tune recommendations, legal audit
M10	Week 12	Performance audit, PWA manifest, public launch

§14 Open Questions

- What is the owner's WhatsApp number for the feedback deep-link?
- Should the Erotic genre require ID verification or just a checkbox age gate?
- Will PickBook ever carry ads? (CC BY-NC novels prohibit commercial use on those pages.)
- Is a user account / login system planned for v4 (enables cross-device sync)?
- How often should the ingestion cron run — daily or hourly?